

Retail Implementation Case Study

Document Information

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Executive Summary

This case study illustrates how a representative multi-channel retailer implemented data governance to unify customer data across channels, improve merchandising data quality, and support personalization initiatives. It is intended as an illustrative reference — adapt the specifics to your own organization's context.

Organization Profile: Multi-channel retailer (e-commerce + brick-and-mortar), regional footprint, loyalty program, multiple POS and e-commerce platforms.

1. Business Context

1.1 The Challenge

- Customer profiles were fragmented across e-commerce, in-store POS, and loyalty systems, undermining personalization efforts
- Product/SKU data was inconsistent between merchandising, e-commerce, and inventory systems
- Marketing could not reliably build a unified view of customer behavior across channels
- Data privacy requirements (CCPA and similar) required clearer tracking of customer data collection and consent

1.2 Business Drivers

- Competitive pressure to deliver personalized, omnichannel customer experiences
 - Marketing ROI concerns from duplicate/inconsistent customer targeting
 - CCPA and state privacy law compliance requirements for consumer data rights requests
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2. Governance Approach

2.1 Program Structure

The Data Governance Council was co-sponsored by the Chief Marketing Officer and Chief Information Officer, balancing customer experience priorities with technical feasibility.

2.2 Phased Rollout

1. **Foundation (Months 1-3):** Charter approval; classification scheme tailored to customer and transactional data
2. **Pilot (Months 4-6):** Customer 360 domain selected as pilot, unifying e-commerce, POS, and loyalty identifiers
3. **Expansion (Months 7-12):** Extended to product/SKU master data across merchandising and e-commerce
4. **Operationalization (Months 13-16):** Governance metrics embedded into marketing and merchandising operating reviews

2.3 Key Capabilities Implemented

- Customer identity resolution across e-commerce, POS, and loyalty systems
- Consent and preference tracking integrated into the data catalog for CCPA-style rights requests
- Product/SKU data quality rules to reduce listing errors and out-of-stock misreporting
- Marketing-aligned Business Data Stewards for customer data, paired with Technical Data Stewards for integration

3. Results

Metric	Before	After (16 Months)
Duplicate customer profile rate	~15%	<3%
Time to fulfill a consumer data rights request	10+ business days	2 business days
Product listing error rate (e-commerce)	~6%	<1.5%
Marketing campaigns using unified Customer 360 data	0%	78%

4. What Worked Well

- Joint Marketing/IT sponsorship ensured the program balanced customer experience value with technical realism
- Building consent/preference tracking directly into the catalog made privacy rights requests dramatically faster
- Demonstrating measurable personalization lift from the Customer 360 pilot secured funding for later phases

5. Challenges Encountered

- Reconciling customer identifiers across systems with no common key required a multi-attribute matching approach (name, email, phone, address) rather than a single identifier
 - Store-level POS systems varied by acquisition history, requiring phased integration rather than a single cutover
 - Marketing teams initially wanted faster access to unified data than the governance review process allowed, requiring a streamlined "fast-track" review for low-risk marketing use cases
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6. Lessons for Other Retail Organizations

- Plan for multi-attribute identity resolution rather than assuming a single clean customer key exists
 - Build consent and preference data into the governance program early — it pays off directly in privacy rights request handling
 - Offer a lightweight, faster governance review path for low-risk, time-sensitive business requests to maintain stakeholder support
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Document Control:

- This is an illustrative template case study for adaptation to your organization
- Replace illustrative metrics and details with your own organization's data before external use
- Pair with the CCPA Implementation Guide in Section 07